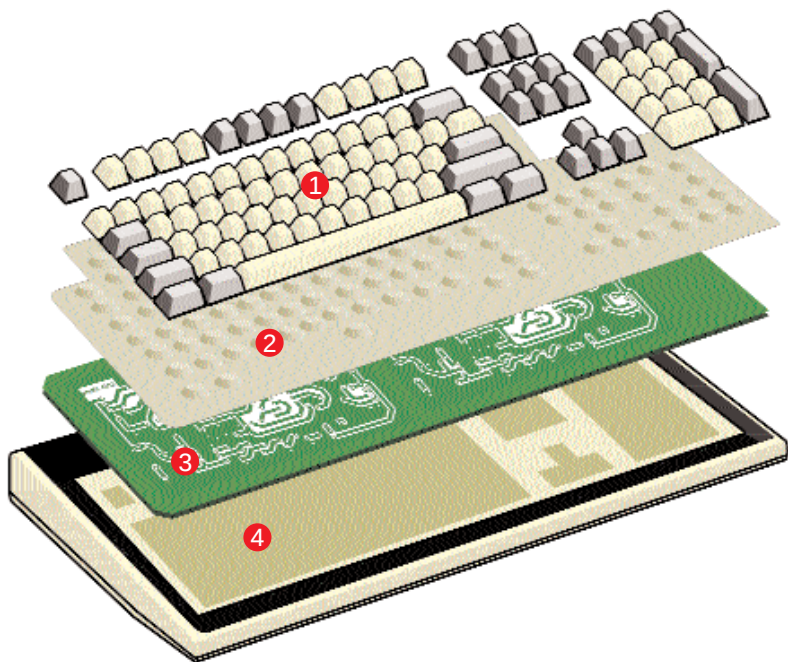




Buying Tips

- ✓ **AESTHETICS:** The keyboard needs to be soft and smooth to the touch. The pegs should be sturdy; many tend to break with the slightest jerk. The keys should be very responsive. Try to fit in a wrist pad to lessen the strain on your wrists.
- ✓ **ERGONOMICS:** An ergonomic keyboard is split in the middle, offsetting the keys where the two hands lie. It does take some time to get used to it; especially since the arrow keys have been completely changed.
- ✓ **HOT KEYS:** Hot keys let you open programs such as messengers, e-mail applications, or a browser, at the touch of a button. Opt for a keyboard that integrates a large number of hot keys in the layout.
- ✓ **WATERPROOFING:** Some of the newer keyboards are waterproof. Water gets drained out via the pores at the bottom of the device. This makes the keyboard durable.
- ✓ **WIRELESS CONNECTIVITY:** Opt for an RF wireless keyboard. Unlike infrared-powered devices, RF wireless connectivity does not require the keyboard to be within line-of-sight. Make it a point to check the number of batteries required. Lastly, make a note of the maximum range at which the keyboard works.

- 1 **Keys:** The plastic buttons that let us type using the keyboard.
- 2 **Membrane:** The membrane structure beneath the plastic keys has small bumps which correspond to all the keys on the top. At a keystroke, the corresponding bump on the membrane is pressed, which passes on to the printed circuit board (PCB) lying beneath the membrane, via the contacts.
- 3 **Printed Circuit Board:** This is the heart of the keyboard. It receives signals from the membrane structure, and accordingly displays a character on the screen.
- 4 **The base:** The plastic base houses the membrane, the PCB of the keyboard.

Quick Find

YOU NEED	A cheap and long lasting solution
Basic Use	
LOOK FOR	A keyboard that sports 104 keys and a PS/2 interface
YOU NEED	The ultimate in comfort and good looks
Inter Use	
LOOK FOR	Ergonomics, a PS/2 or USB interface, a palm rest and hot keys

Do Remember

- Douglas Engelbart invented a number of interactive, user-friendly information access systems that we take for granted today: the computer mouse was one of his inventions.
- The QWERTY keyboard layout was invented by Christopher L. Sholes in 1867. This layout is dominant even today. It was used on the Sholes & Glidden type-Writer, manufactured by E. Remington & Sons in 1874.
- Tomorrow's computer keyboard might be played more like an accordion than a piano, says a Cornell University ergonomist. This, he says, is because a prototype vertical split keyboard (VK) allows two to three times more typing movements to stay in safe, low-risk positions for carpal tunnel syndrome, compared with a traditional keyboard.



The Future

If you're using a standard QWERTY keyboard-and most of us do-your keyboard design is over a century old. Keyboard design has stagnated over the last few years. However, some vendors have launched products that are wacky, to say the least, and ergonomic as well.

For instance, SafeType Inc launched a keyboard that they claim is designed as per scientific biomechanical principles and virtually eliminates the high-stress postures that contribute to Repetitive Stress Injury (RSI). This device looks like a standard QWERTY keyboard that's been broken up into three equal pieces. The two outermost pieces are placed vertically, with keys on the outside, and a couple of mirrors placed alongside. The horizontal middle piece has the number keys.